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de Civitate Bristol, inter se consuluerunt & conspiraverunt, ad diminuendam Regiam Authoritatem, Regalem Prærogativam & Potestatem, & Regimen ejusdem Dominis Regis nunc in præmissis, ac ad eundem Ordinem infringendum & eludendum; ac in prosecutione & executione conspirationis prædictæ, ipsi iidem Willielmus Archiepiscopus Cantuariensis, Willielmus Episcopus Asaphensis, Franciscus Episcopus Eliensis, Johannes Episcopus Cicestrensis, Thomas Episcopus Bathonensis & Wellensis, Thomas Episcopus Petriburgensis, & Jonathan Episcopus Bristollensis dicto decimo octavo die Maii, Anno Regni dicti Domini Regis nunc quarto supradicto, vi & armis, &c. apud Westmonasterium prædictum in Comitatu Middlesexie prædicto, illicitè, malitiosè, seditiosè & scandalosè quoddam falsum, fictum, perniciosum, & seditiosum libellum, in scriptis de eodem Domino Rege & Regali Declaratione & Ordine prædictis (prætenso Petitionis) fabricaverunt, composuerunt & scripserunt, & fabricari componi & scribi causaverunt, & eundem falsum, fictum, malitiosum, perniciosum, & seditiosum libellum per ipsos prædictum Willielmum Archiepiscopum Cantuariensem, Willielmum Episcopum Asaphensem, Franciscum Episcopum Eliensem, Johannem Episcopum Cicestrensem, Thomam Episcopum Bathonensem & Wellensem, Thomam Episcopum Petriburgensem, & Jonathanum Episcopum Bristollensem manibus suis propriis respectivè subscriptum die, & anno, & loco ultimo mentionatis in præsentia dicti Domini Regis nunc vi & armis, &c. publicaverunt, & publicari

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& publicari causaverunt; in quo quidem falso, ficto, malitioso, pernicioso & seditioso libello continetur----

The humble Petition of *William*, Archbishop of *Canterbury*, and of divers of the Suffragan Bishops of that Province (now present with him) in behalf of themselves and others of their absent Brethren, and of the Clergy of their respective Diocesses,

Humbly sheweth,

TH A T the great Averseness they find in themselves to the distributing and publishing in all their Churches, your Majesty's late Declaration for Liberty of Conscience, proceedeth neither from any want of Duty and Obedience to your Majesty; our Holy Mother the Church of *England* being both in her Principles and in her constant Practice unquestionably Loyal, and having to her great Honour, been more than once publickly acknowledged to be so by your gracious Majesty; nor yet from any want of due Tenderneſs to Dissenters, in relation to whom they are willing to come to such a Temper as shall be thought fit, when that
Matter

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Matter shall be considered and settled in Parliament and Convocation. But, among many other Considerations, from this especially, because that Declaration is founded upon such a dispensing Power, as hath been often declared illegal in Parliament, and particularly in the Years 1662, and 1672, and the beginning of your Majesty's Reign; and is a Matter of so great Moment and Consequence to the whole Nation, both in Church and State, that your Petitioners cannot in Prudence, Honour, or Conscience, so far make themselves Parties to it, as the Distribution of it all over the Nation, and the solemn Publication of it once and again, even in God's House, and in the time of his Divine Service, must amount to, in common and reasonable Construction.

-----In contemptum dicti Domini Regis nunc, & Legum hujus regni Angliæ, manifestum, in malum exemplum omnium aliorum in tali casu delinquentium, ac contra pacem dicti Domini Regis nunc, Coronam & Dignitatem suas, &c. Unde idem Attornatus dicti Domini Regis nunc generalis pro eodem Domino Rege petit advisamentum Curiae hic in præmissis, & debitum legis processum versus præfatos *Willielmum Archiepiscopum Cantuariensem, Willielmum Episcopum Asaphensem, Franciscum Episcopum Eliensem, Johannem Episcopum Cice-strensem, Thomam Episcopum Bathonensem & Wellensem, Thomam Episcopum Petriburgensem, & Jonathamum Episcopum Bristollensem fieri;*

ad

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*ad respondendum dicto Domino Regi de & in
præmissis, &c.*

T. Powys.

W. Williams.

Mr. Att. Gen. My Lord, we humbly pray, that according to the Rules of the Court in such Cases, my Lord Archbishop of *Canterbury* and my Lords the Bishops may plead to the Information.

Mr. Soll. Gen. My Lords the Bishops are here in Custody in Court, upon the highest Commitment that can be in this Kingdom, to wit, That of the King in Council; and we pray that, according to the Course of the Court, they may plead to the Information presently.

L. C. Just. What does his Grace and my Lords the Bishops say to it?

Mr. Serj. Pemberton. Will your Lordship give us leave, who are of Council for his Grace my Lord of *Canterbury*, and the rest of my Lords the Bishops, to speak a Word in this Matter?

L. C. Just. Ay, Brother, go on.

Mr. Serj. Pemberton. That which we have to desire of your Lordship and the Court is this; We have now heard this Information read, and 'tis plain we could know nothing of this before, the Warrant of Commitment being only in general for a Libel; and this being a Case of the greatest Consequence, peradventure, that ever was in *Westminster-Hall*, (that, I think,
I may